elements of Christian messianism and Vaishnav purity with the ancient tribal religion of Sarnaism—is a giant tactical leap. The party is guided by sound logic, though. When it tried its aggressive Ram mandir plank in other parts of 'mainstream' India—say, in Bengal and Odisha, where Durga, Kali and Jagannath are the presiding deities—the return on investment didn't entirely match up. The Adivasi world is at an even further remove.

Lessons learnt, it's going for embracing popular beliefs, cultures and icons. Here's where its newfound love for Birsa, the heroic freedom fighter seen as Bhagwan (God) or Dharti Aba (Father of the Earth) by his people, fits in. The turn was visible in 2021, when the Modi government declared November 15, Birsa's birth anniversary, as Janjaatiya Gaurav Divas, or Tribal Pride Day. This year is his 147th birth anniversary, three years still to go for the sesquicentennial. Yet the Modi government found the occasion worthy enough to merit a grand country-wide celebration.





The reason is not hard to guess. Assembly elections are due next year in nine states with sizeable tribal populations: Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Telangana, Karnataka, besides Tripura, Meghalaya, Nagaland and Mizoram. Last time, of these states, the BJP had won only Tripura on its own strength, and only piggybacked its way to power via popular regional parties in Nagaland and Meghalaya. It could not retain Chhattisgarh, which it had won thrice consecutively, or Birsa's homeland Jharkhand in 2019—losing out just months after the spectacular general election win.

The chief reason was tribal disenchantment. In Jharkhand, while the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha-Rashtriya Janata Dal-Congress alliance secured 25 out of 28 reserved tribal seats in an assembly of 81, the BJP got only two. That trend had already been visible by 2017, with the Congress winning 25 of 29 reserved tribal seats in Chhattisgarh; the BJP got only three. In neighbouring MP, as the BJP lost to the Congress by two seats in a cliffhanger, the tribal vote was again decisive: the BJP got only 15 out of 47 reserved seats for tribals; 30 seats went to the Congress. In all, the BJP had lost 120 of the 180 seats reserved for SC/STs in the 2018 assembly polls in MP, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh. The spinning of a new narrative to win back the tribals, then, comes as no surprise.

WHY BIRSA?

Birsa Munda, born in 1875 in Khunti district of today's Jharkhand, is a complex figure who combines the personas of prophet and revolutionary. Described as a young man with "remarkably attractive features...a face intelligent and smiling, pensive and thoughtful", he had a spiritual-political trajectory that may not be an automatic fit for Hindutva. First converted to Christianity by the German Mission School as Birsa David, then briefly the Catholic church, he reverted to his native faith Sarnaism once he saw conversions as a colonial ploy. But he brought back to it strong Biblical elements: revelation, doomsday, resurrection, miracle healing...and most of all, monotheism. The Munda, Oraon and Kharia communities began to see in him a god-like figure, a redeemer of their woes, and flocked to him to be cured of ailments. But the decisive turn came when he lent his messianic aura to armed rebellion. Present-day Jharkhand and contiguous regions in east India had seen a series of revolts through the 19th century against both the colonial British as well as native *dikus* (outsiders), a new money-lending class that brought the tribals under the yoke as bondsmen through usurious land rent and other means of exploitation. The Birsaite revolt was short-lived but spectacular, and granted the tribals a talisman for all times—they believe his spirit still roams free in the forests.

Modern corporates may often answer to the description of *diku* in tribal eyes, but politics finds ingenious ways around that gap. Alliances and cooption are the first tool mainstream